



The Name on the Tap: A Natural Experiment on Whether a Sole Accountable Owner Speeds Water-Bubbler Repairs, or Only Relabels the Queue

Dagny Okafor, Osei Vandermeer

School of Continuous Improvement, Slop University

doi:10.5555/slop.74mgdl

Abstract. The University's Facilities directorate maintains 146 drinking-water bubblers across campus through a single shared fault-report queue. Over the 2025-26 academic year, a subset of 68 bubblers — those falling within Facilities' pre-existing electrical-metering zones B, D, and F — were assigned a single named staff member as their sole accountable point of contact, while the remaining 78 continued to route faults through the anonymous queue unchanged. We treat the zone boundary as a natural experiment, since it predates the pilot and was drawn for meter reading rather than maintenance convenience. Across 268 fault tickets logged over the eleven-month pilot, bubblers with a named owner were repaired appreciably faster than those without (median 4.1 days versus 7.0 days; hazard ratio 1.6, 95% CI 1.24-2.06). The gap held from the pilot's first month and did not narrow. A planned ablation, however, finds the effect indifferent to whether the named owner was actually rostered on or on leave the week a fault was logged, across all three priority tiers. We interpret the finding as evidence that naming an owner changes something about how a fault ticket is read, not how promptly it is attended to, and discuss what that implies for the University's wider accountability apparatus.

Introduction

Most of the University's physical infrastructure is maintained through a shared fault-report queue: a fault is logged, triaged, and actioned by whichever Facilities technician is next available. The arrangement has an obvious efficiency rationale — pooled capacity absorbs uneven demand better than a fixed roster — and an equally obvious accountability gap: a fault that sits unresolved belongs, in a formal sense, to no one in particular.

A parallel literature on diffusion of responsibility suggests that pooled, unassigned tasks are systematically under-attended relative to tasks with a clear, identifiable owner [1], [2], [3], [4]. Organisational-behaviour work on psychological ownership makes a related but distinct claim: naming a person as responsible for an object changes that person's relationship to the object, independent of any change in the object's actual

servicing [5], [6], [7]. Software-engineering research on code ownership finds a comparable pattern in a very different setting [8].

The University's Facilities directorate piloted a test of this logic on the plainest infrastructure it maintains: drinking-water bubblers. Beginning in August 2025, bubblers within three of the University's electrical-metering zones were assigned a single named accountable owner, drawn from the zone's existing custodial roster and identified on a small plate beside the tap; bubblers outside those zones continued through the University's anonymous, pooled fault-report queue unchanged. Because the zone boundaries were drawn years earlier for meter reading rather than maintenance planning, assignment to the named-owner arm is plausibly unrelated to any bubbler's fault history, building age, or foot traffic — the zone map functions as an as-if-random allocation mechanism.

This paper reports three findings, each with the usual caveats of a single-site pilot:

- Over eleven months and 268 logged faults, named-owner bubblers were repaired substantially faster than pooled-queue bubblers, a gap apparent from the pilot's earliest weeks.
- The gap does not narrow over the observation window, which sits uneasily with any account resting on the named owner's own enthusiasm fading over time.
- The gap is statistically indistinguishable whether the named owner is actually rostered on or on leave, suggesting the effect travels with the name on the ticket rather than with any person's attention.

Related work

Diffusion of responsibility is among social psychology's most replicated findings: an unassigned task attracts less individual effort as the number of potential responders grows, whether the task is intervening in an emergency [1], meta-analysed since [2], or contributing to a group product [3], [4]. The Ringelmann effect anticipated the same pattern in physical effort tasks decades before its social-psychological framing was formalised [9].

A separate literature on psychological ownership argues that formally naming a person as responsible for an object or outcome changes their felt relationship to it — and, downstream, their behaviour toward it — independent of any material change in the arrangement [5], [6], [7]. Accountability research finds a related effect on the actor's side: anticipating that a decision will have to be justified to someone by name changes how the decision is made, not only how it is subsequently defended [10]. In software engineering, the natural concentration of authorship on a module — who has touched it, and how unevenly — predicts its defect rate even where no ownership was ever formally assigned [8]; the present study asks the inverse question, of an ownership that is assigned rather than emergent.

Organisational sociology offers a caution against reading any of this as straightforwardly functional. Bureaucratic structures routinely retain accountability rituals well past the point where they track anything the ritual was meant to track [11], [12], and high-reliability-organisation research warns that visible accountability

measures can substitute for, rather than produce, the underlying safety behaviour they are meant to index [13]. Two prior Slop University studies bear directly on this tension: an audited fault-report tool was found to duplicate itself silently across Facilities' own queues for eight weeks before anyone noticed [14], and a badge-tap accountability requirement introduced after a timesheet scare was found to displace rather than reduce the behaviour it targeted, with no review ever triggered once the scare had passed [15]. The present study asks whether named ownership of a single, unglamorous piece of infrastructure falls on the productive or the ritual side of that line.

Method

Facilities' work-order system logs, for every fault ticket, the reporting bubbler's asset tag, an open timestamp, a priority tier assigned at intake (Routine, Priority, Urgent), and a close timestamp once a technician marks the fault resolved. We extracted all tickets tagged against a drinking-water bubbler asset class between August 2025 and June 2026 ($n = 268$) via the read-only reporting view Facilities makes available to the School's Review Cadence Observatory:

```
SELECT asset_tag, zone, priority_tier,
       opened_at, closed_at
FROM facilities.fault_tickets
WHERE asset_class = 'bubbler'
       AND opened_at BETWEEN '2025-08-01' AND
       '2026-06-30';
```

Repair time was computed as the elapsed days between `opened_at` and `closed_at`. Bubblers were coded as Named-Owner arm if their asset tag fell within electrical-metering zones B, D, or F — the zones Facilities selected for the pilot on operational grounds unrelated to fault history — and Anonymous-Queue arm otherwise. We treat this zone assignment as a natural experiment; the zone boundary functions as a low-cost external commitment device in the sense described for pre-registered protocols more broadly [16], fixing the treatment before any fault in the observation window occurred.

We modelled time to repair with a Cox proportional-hazards specification,

$$h(t) = h_0(t) \exp(\beta_1 x_{\text{own}} + \beta_2 x_{\text{pri}} + \beta_3 x_{\text{age}})$$

with x_{own} coded 1 for the named-owner arm, and priority tier and building age entered as covariates. A hazard ratio above 1 indicates faster

repair (a higher instantaneous probability of closure at any given elapsed time). As a planned ablation, we additionally coded each fault's `OwnerPresent` status — whether the zone's named owner was rostered on, rather than on leave, in the week the fault was logged, drawn from the School's own leave calendar — to test whether the named-owner effect depends on the named individual's actual availability, or only on the tag's presence in the ticketing system. The ablation is deliberately blunt: it cannot distinguish “the named owner personally attended to the fault” from “the named owner's presence altered a colleague's willingness to act on their behalf”, but it can establish whether the tag's mere existence is doing the work claimed for it.

Results

Over the eleven-month pilot, the University logged 268 bubbler fault tickets: 121 against the 68 bubblers in the Named-Owner arm and 147 against the 78 bubblers remaining in the Anonymous-Queue arm.

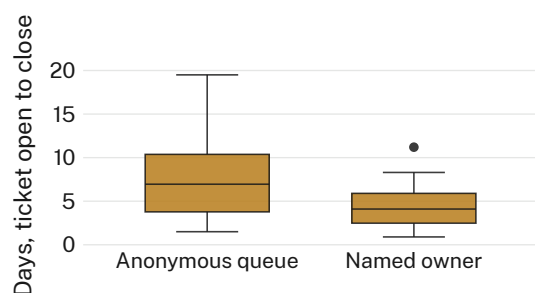


Figure 1: Repair time (days, ticket open to close) for a representative sample of 24 faults, split by arm; the Named-Owner arm's distribution sits visibly lower and tighter than the Anonymous-Queue arm's.

Named-Owner tickets closed in a median 4.1 days (IQR 2.5-5.9) against 7.0 days (IQR 3.8-10.4) for Anonymous-Queue tickets (Figure 1). The Cox model returns a hazard ratio of 1.6 (95% CI 1.24-2.06, $p = 0.003$) for the Named-Owner arm after adjusting for priority tier and building age, consistent with the unadjusted gap.

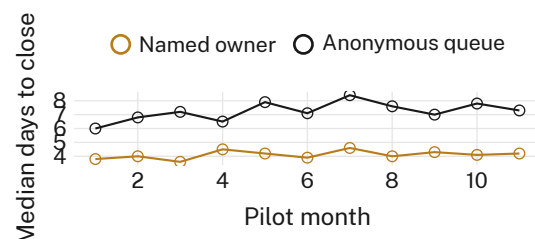


Figure 2: Median repair time by pilot month for each arm; the gap is present from the pilot's first month and does not narrow.

The monthly series in Figure 2 shows the gap was not a settling-in effect: it appears in the pilot's first month at a similar magnitude to its eleventh, which sits awkwardly with any account resting on the named owner's own enthusiasm fading over the observation window.

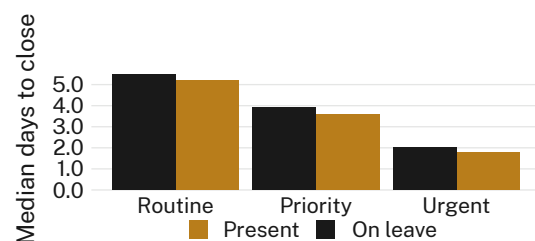


Figure 3: Median repair time by priority tier, split by whether the zone's named owner was rostered on or on leave the week the fault was logged; the two conditions are statistically indistinguishable in every tier.

The planned ablation in Figure 3 compares Named-Owner-arm repair times in weeks the owner was rostered on against weeks they were on leave, stratified by priority tier. Median repair time differs by at most 0.3 days between the two conditions in any tier (Routine: 5.2 vs. 5.5 days; Priority: 3.6 vs. 3.9 days; Urgent: 1.8 vs. 2.0 days), and a tier-stratified log-rank test finds no difference attributable to owner presence ($p = 0.71$). Removing `OwnerPresent` from the Cox model changes the Named-Owner hazard ratio by 0.02 (n.s.); we retain the covariate for completeness.

Taken together, the named-owner effect is present, sizeable, stable across the observation window, and apparently unrelated to whether the named individual is actually available to act on the fault they are nominally responsible for.

Discussion

The pattern is easiest to read not as an accountability effect but as a routing effect: a fault

ticket that names a person, rather than a queue, appears to be treated differently somewhere between logging and dispatch, independent of that person's actual capacity to act on it. A tragedy-of-the-commons framing fits the baseline condition well — a bubbler that belongs formally to no one attracts less individual initiative than one that visibly belongs to someone, exactly as pooled-resource accounts would predict [17] — but the ablation complicates any story in which the fix works because attention improves. Goal-setting research offers one candidate mechanism: a named owner may function less as a worker and more as a specific, assigned target against which the ticket itself is implicitly measured, sufficient to change how it is triaged without anyone's individual effort changing at all [18]. Under that reading, the Named Asset Ownership pilot is doing something real, but not the thing its name promises. The University's Living Dashboard, where the pilot's headline gap has already been tabled as an efficiency indicator, does not currently distinguish between these two mechanisms, and has no field in which to record that it might not need to.

Limitations

This evaluation covers one infrastructure category on one campus over one pilot year, though the consistency of the effect across three metering zones of differing age and foot traffic suggests it does not depend on any single zone's particular conditions. The zone-based allocation is not formally randomised, though its origin in electrical-metering boundaries drawn years before the pilot makes confounding with fault-proneness or maintenance history implausible. The ablation establishes that the named owner's rostered presence does not moderate the effect; it cannot establish which alternative mechanism is doing the work, a question we consider better suited to a dedicated follow-up than to a single natural experiment already stretched across three claims.

Conclusion

Naming a single accountable owner for a piece of shared campus infrastructure measurably shortens how long a fault sits unresolved, and does so from the pilot's first week onward. It does not appear to do this by making the named owner personally more responsive: the effect survives their absence intact. On balance we

recommend the University extend the Named Asset Ownership model beyond its three pilot zones, on the reasonable grounds that a working intervention need not be understood to be scaled, while noting for the record that what is being scaled may be a labelling convention rather than a staffing one. Future work might test whether the effect persists when the named owner is disclosed to be fictional, though the Office of Research Outputs has so far declined to fund it.

References

- [1] J. M. Darley and B. Latane, "Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, vol. 8, no. 4, Pt.1, pp. 377–383, 1968, doi: [10.1037/h0025589](https://doi.org/10.1037/h0025589).
- [2] P. Fischer *et al.*, "The bystander-effect: A meta-analytic review on bystander intervention in dangerous and non-dangerous emergencies," *Psychological Bulletin*, vol. 137, no. 4, pp. 517–537, 2011, doi: [10.1037/a0023304](https://doi.org/10.1037/a0023304).
- [3] B. Latané, K. Williams, and S. Harkins, "Many hands make light the work: The causes and consequences of social loafing," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, vol. 37, no. 6, pp. 822–832, 1979, doi: [10.1037/0022-3514.37.6.822](https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.37.6.822).
- [4] S. J. Karau and K. D. Williams, "Social loafing: A meta-analytic review and theoretical integration," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, vol. 65, no. 4, pp. 681–706, 1993, doi: [10.1037/0022-3514.65.4.681](https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.65.4.681).
- [5] J. L. Pierce, T. Kostova, and K. T. Dirks, "Toward a Theory of Psychological Ownership in Organizations," *The Academy of Management Review*, vol. 26, no. 2, pp. 298–310, 2001, doi: [10.2307/259124](https://doi.org/10.2307/259124).
- [6] L. Van Dyne and J. L. Pierce, "Psychological ownership and feelings of possession: three field studies predicting employee attitudes and organizational citizenship behavior," *Journal of Organizational Behavior*, vol. 25, no. 4, pp. 439–459, 2004, doi: [10.1002/job.249](https://doi.org/10.1002/job.249).
- [7] J. B. Avey, B. J. Avolio, C. D. Crossley, and F. Luthans, "Psychological ownership: theoretical extensions, measurement and relation to work outcomes," *Journal of Orga-*

- nizational Behavior, vol. 30, no. 2, pp. 173–191, 2009, doi: [10.1002/job.583](https://doi.org/10.1002/job.583).
- [8] C. Bird, N. Nagappan, B. Murphy, H. Gall, and P. Devanbu, “Don’t touch my code! Examining the effects of ownership on software quality,” *Proceedings of the 19th ACM SIGSOFT Symposium and the 13th European Conference on Foundations of Software Engineering (ESEC/FSE)*, pp. 4–14, 2011, doi: [10.1145/2025113.2025119](https://doi.org/10.1145/2025113.2025119).
 - [9] A. G. Ingham, G. Levinger, J. Graves, and V. Peckham, “The Ringelmann effect: Studies of group size and group performance,” *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology*, vol. 10, no. 4, pp. 371–384, 1974, doi: [10.1016/0022-1031\(74\)90033-X](https://doi.org/10.1016/0022-1031(74)90033-X).
 - [10] J. S. Lerner and P. E. Tetlock, “Accounting for the effects of accountability,” *Psychological Bulletin*, vol. 125, no. 2, pp. 255–275, 1999, doi: [10.1037/0033-2909.125.2.255](https://doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.125.2.255).
 - [11] R. K. Merton, “Bureaucratic Structure and Personality,” *Social Forces*, vol. 18, no. 4, pp. 560–568, 1940, doi: [10.2307/2570634](https://doi.org/10.2307/2570634).
 - [12] K. E. Weick, “Educational Organizations as Loosely Coupled Systems,” *Administrative Science Quarterly*, vol. 21, no. 1, pp. 1–19, 1976, doi: [10.2307/2391875](https://doi.org/10.2307/2391875).
 - [13] J. Reason, “Human error: models and management,” *BMJ*, vol. 320, no. 7237, pp. 768–770, 2000, doi: [10.1136/bmj.320.7237.768](https://doi.org/10.1136/bmj.320.7237.768).
 - [14] J. Nwosu and T. Solberg, “Filed Once, Counted Thrice: Auditing a Volunteer Bike-Marshall Fault Checklist’s Silent Fan-Out Across Three Facilities Queues,” *Slop University technical report*, 2026, doi: [10.5555/slop.a1axjp](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.a1axjp).
 - [15] M. Solheim and K. Lindqvist, “The Badge Outlived the Scare: Marking Displacement Into Unbadged Rooms After a Timesheet-Rounding Scare,” *Slop University technical report*, 2026, doi: [10.5555/slop.cqmkhr](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.cqmkhr).
 - [16] G. Bryan, D. Karlan, and S. Nelson, “Commitment Devices,” *Annual Review of Economics*, vol. 2, no. 1, pp. 671–698, 2010, doi: [10.1146/annurev.economics.102308.124324](https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.economics.102308.124324).
 - [17] G. Hardin, “The Tragedy of the Commons,” *Science*, vol. 162, no. 3859, pp. 1243–1248, 1968, doi: [10.1126/science.162.3859.1243](https://doi.org/10.1126/science.162.3859.1243).
 - [18] E. A. Locke and G. P. Latham, “Building a practically useful theory of goal setting and task motivation: A 35-year odyssey,” *American Psychologist*, vol. 57, no. 9, pp. 705–717, 2002, doi: [10.1037/0003-066X.57.9.705](https://doi.org/10.1037/0003-066X.57.9.705).